

Guinea-Bissau



Known as Portuguese Guinea while a colony, Guinea-Bissau lies on Africa's west coast. Since 1994, its nascent democracy has been plagued by coups and rebellions.



GEOGRAPHY

Low-lying, apart from savanna highlands in northeast. Rainforests and swamps are found along coastal areas.



CLIMATE

Tropical, with wet season May–November and dry season December–April. Hot, dry *harmattan* desert wind blows during dry season.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The largest ethnic group is the Balante, who live in the south. Though only around 1% of the population, the mixed Portuguese–African *mestiços* dominate the top ranks of government and bureaucracy. Most people live and work on small family farms, grouped in self-contained villages. The bulk of the urban population live in Bissau, where they face economic hardship. Narcotics traffickers are taking advantage of the ongoing instability.



THE ECONOMY

Mostly subsistence farming. Lack of sufficiency in rice staple. Main cash crop is cashew nuts. Major cocaine transit route from South America to Europe. Offshore oil as yet untapped. Fisheries and timber potential.



INSIGHT: In 1974, Guinea-Bissau became the first Portuguese colony to gain independence



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Rep. of Guinea-Bissau

DATE OF FORMATION: 1974

CAPITAL: Bissau

POPULATION: 1.61 million

TOTAL AREA: 13,946 sq. miles
(36,120 sq. km)

DENSITY: 148 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Portuguese Creole, Balante, Fulani, Malinke, Portuguese*

RELIGIONS: Indigenous beliefs 52%, Muslim 40%, Christian 8%

ETHNIC MIX: Balante 30%, other 24%, Fulani 20%, Mandyako 14%, Mandinka 12%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: CFA franc = 100 centimes